The first 8 steps of an AI feature, in plain words

A small guide to steps 1 to 8 of "The AI Feature Method, A to Z", with Yalla as the example. Written for a product builder who is not an engineer.

> **What these 8 steps are.** The full method has 14 steps in 5 phases. Steps 1 to 8 are the first two phases, **Frame** (find a job worth doing) and **Define** (decide what good looks like). They are everything you decide **before anyone builds**. This is the part you, the product person, own. Steps 9 to 14 are build, ship and learn.

> **One picture to keep in your head.** Think of the AI model as a **new employee**: extremely well read, fast, but has never seen your business, and sometimes says wrong things with full confidence. The 8 steps are how you would hire and set up that person properly.

The 8 steps on one page

#	Step	The question in plain words	The hiring picture	What you hold at the end
1	Mine the jobs	What work is worth giving to AI?	List the work that needs doing	List of 10 jobs with proof
2	Test the AI fit	Does this job need AI at all?	Do we need a hire, or just a checklist?	One chosen first feature
3	Set the autonomy level	How much may it do without asking?	What can they do without a manager?	One paragraph: level, owner, undo
4	Build the golden set	What does "good" look like?	The exam and its answer key	30 to 100 examples with ideal answers
5	Pick pattern + knowledge	Where does the truth come from?	The workflow and the files we hand over	A box diagram of the flow
6	Choose the model	Which AI for which step?	Cheapest candidate who passes the exam	A table of models with scores
7	Design the trust UX	What happens when it is wrong?	How customers see and correct the work	Screens for label, why, fix, feedback
8	Set the economics	What does each use cost?	Salary, budget and spending limits	Cost sheet, pricing, caps

How each step card is built

In plain words explains the idea. **Words you will hear** translates what engineers say. **Your job as the builder** is the decision you make or the question you ask. **Yalla, by the method** is how the method PDF applies it to Yalla. **Yalla today** is what the code really does now (from Youssef's AI review and the repo). **You are done when** is the gate to move on.

FRAME · step 1 of 8

1 Mine the jobs

What work is worth giving to AI?

IN PLAIN WORDS Before hiring anyone, you list the work that is eating people's time. You look at evidence (what users do, where they give up), not at a cool demo you saw.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **Job story:** One sentence: when [situation], I want to [job], so I can [result].
- **Evidence:** Real numbers or observations that prove the pain exists.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Write the top 10 jobs with proof for each. Ask: is this a real, frequent pain, or just a missing normal feature?

YALLA, BY THE METHOD The method's evidence for Yalla: people open their Instagram saved posts 4 times per plan, and friend groups drop the chat after about 20 messages without deciding. The job is: *when my group can't decide, I want 3 ready plans from one sentence, so we actually go out.*

YALLA TODAY Done. The PRD already splits Yalla into jobs A to F (understand the request, fetch places, compose plans, write copy, and so on).

You are done when: At least 3 jobs with real evidence and a clear link to usage or revenue. If none, don't build AI yet.

FRAME · step 2 of 8

2 Test the AI fit

Does this job need AI at all?

IN PLAIN WORDS For each job, decide if you need a smart hire (a model), a simple checklist (rules in code), or just a better screen. About a third of "AI features" are better as a filter or a rule.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **LLM / model:** The AI that reads and writes language.
- **Rules / code:** Normal programming. Exact, instant, free per use.
- **Classic ML:** A model trained on your own numbers, such as a ranking or a forecast.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Give each job a verdict: no AI, AI helps, or AI is the core. Pick the first feature you can **prove**, not the most impressive one.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD Plan generation is the product itself, so AI is core. But the method says start small: a parser that understands the sentence (small, fast, low risk) feeding a picker that follows rules.

YALLA TODAY Partly. The split is right on paper, but in the code one big model does everything, including the maths of the day (times, opening hours, driving). Code then corrects it. And the part AI is best at, understanding Arabic and Franco-Arabic, is done by English keyword matching, so "بدنا نتغدى بالبترون" does not find Batroun.

You are done when: The chosen feature has a named job, usable data, and a low-risk first version.

FRAME · step 3 of 8

3 Set the autonomy level

How much may the AI do without asking?

IN PLAIN WORDS A new employee does not sign contracts on day one. You decide on purpose how much freedom the AI gets, and which human owns the result.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **L0 Inform:** Only shows information.
- **L1 Suggest:** Proposes, the human acts.
- **L2 Draft:** Makes the thing, the human edits and approves.
- **L3 Act with approval:** Does it after a tap.
- **L4 Act alone:** Does it, human reviews later.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Pick the lowest level that still gives the value. Write down who owns the outcome, how a mistake is undone, and what proof would let you raise the level later.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD Plans are L2: the AI drafts three plans, the group swaps and removes stops. Booking would be L3: only after a tap, with a cancel link. Never L4 for anything that spends money.

YALLA TODAY Partly. The app behaves as L2, but I found no written autonomy decision in the repo. Worth one paragraph in the PRD before booking features arrive.

You are done when: A named human owns every outcome. Every action above L2 has an undo.

DEFINE · step 4 of 8

4 Build the golden set

What does "good" look like, exactly?

IN PLAIN WORDS This is the exam with its answer key. You collect real inputs and write the ideal answer for each, **before** anyone writes a prompt. Without it, "the AI is good" is only an opinion.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **Golden set:** 30 to 100 real examples with the ideal answer.
- **Rubric:** The marking guide: what earns points, what is an instant fail.
- **Eval:** Running the exam automatically and getting a score.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER You own this. It is the real spec of an AI feature. Include easy cases, tricky ones, and nasty ones (empty text, impossible request, someone trying to trick the AI). Two people should mark the same way.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD 60 real group chats turned into one-sentence requests, each with the plan the group actually chose. Plus 15 impossible ones (closed day, no budget, opposite moods) where the right answer is a clarifying question.

YALLA TODAY Partly. A strong exam exists for the parser (`evals/parser.golden.json` : Arabic, Franco-Arabic, trick inputs, impossible requests). But the parser it tests was never built and nothing runs the exam. There is no exam yet for the plans themselves.

You are done when: At least 30 items, half in Arabic, and two humans agree on 80% or more of the marks.

DEFINE · step 5 of 8

5 Pick the pattern and the knowledge source

Where does the truth live, and how does the AI get it?

IN PLAIN WORDS The new hire is very well read but knows nothing about your business. You decide the workflow (who does what, in which order) and which files you hand over at each step. Never accept "the model will know".

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **Chain:** Several small steps in a row instead of one giant request.
- **Context:** What you put in front of the model for this one request.
- **Retrieval / tools:** Fetching facts from your database or an outside service.
- **Schema:** The fixed shape of the answer, so code can read it.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Draw the flow as boxes: which box is code, which is search, which is AI. For each AI box: what goes in, what must never go in, and what shape comes out.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD Sentence → small model understands it → search finds places that are open, close enough and in budget → planner builds 3 plans → small model writes the descriptions. Places and hours come from data, never from the model's memory.

YALLA TODAY Partly. Today it is: keyword matching → Google Places → one large call with about 180 places → code repairs the result. Youssef's review proposes the clean chain. One open choice: the method lets a top model build the plans, the review says do it in code. My view: scheduling is rules and maths, so code; let step 6 settle it with exam scores.

You are done when: Every AI step has a defined input, output shape and knowledge source.

DEFINE · step 6 of 8

6 Choose the model

Which AI, for which step?

IN PLAIN WORDS You are choosing between candidates of different seniority and salary. You don't hire by reputation. You give both the same exam (step 4) and hire the cheapest one that passes.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **Small / mid / frontier:** Model sizes. For Claude: Haiku, Sonnet, Opus. Bigger is smarter, slower and more expensive.
- **Latency:** How long the user waits.
- **Fallback:** The backup model if the first one is down.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Ask for two candidates per AI step: the obvious one and one tier cheaper. Ask for four numbers each: pass rate, serious fails, speed, cost per call. Decide on numbers, not names.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD Understanding the sentence: small model. Building plans: top model (in the method's example the mid model broke time rules in 18% of cases). Descriptions: small model.

YALLA TODAY Missing. The largest model (Opus) runs every step, even simple ones like reading a reel caption or a status check. No decision is backed by exam numbers, because the exam is not running.

You are done when: The choice is backed by golden set numbers, with a backup model noted.

DEFINE · step 7 of 8

7 Design the trust experience

What happens on screen when the AI is wrong?

IN PLAIN WORDS The AI will be wrong sometimes. Users don't judge the model, they judge how it feels to be wrong. A suggestion with a visible reason and a one-tap fix survives many errors. A silent mistake does not.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **AI label:** A clear mark that this content came from AI.
- **Feedback signal:** Accepted, edited, rejected. Free exam material from real users.
- **Failure states:** What the screen shows when the AI is unsure, has no data, or is down.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Design five things: the label, the "why", the one-tap correction, the feedback capture, and the loading and failure screens.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD Three plan cards appear one by one. Each stop has Swap and Remove. "Why this?" shows the reason (open now, 12 min away, under budget). Regenerate asks what to change. A thumbs up on the plan the group chose.

YALLA TODAY Partly. Swap, Add and a "Closed at this time. Swap it?" warning exist, and a fix that makes Swap and Add respect hours, budget and diet is waiting on an unmerged branch. Missing: nothing records what users swap, remove or pick, so every free signal is thrown away.

You are done when: A wrong output can be seen, explained, corrected and reversed without leaving the screen.

DEFINE · step 8 of 8

8 Set the economics

What does each use cost, and who pays?

IN PLAIN WORDS A normal feature costs money to build, then runs almost free. An AI feature costs money **every time someone uses it**. So you set the budget and the limits before launch, not after the first invoice.

WORDS YOU WILL HEAR

- **Tokens:** The unit AI is billed in, roughly pieces of words.
- **Cost per use:** The whole chain for one plan, including retries and regenerates.
- **Cap:** A hard limit per user or per day that cannot be exceeded.
- **Caching:** Reusing an earlier result instead of paying again.

YOUR JOB AS THE BUILDER Get the cost per plan, multiply by expected volume, and decide the packaging: free with a limit, pay per use, or a paid tier. Then set caps and a budget alert.

YALLA, BY THE METHOD The method's illustration (invented numbers): about $0.045 per plan with 1.3 regenerates on average. At 50,000 plans a month that is $2,250, cut to about $900 with caching and a cheaper first draft. Free: 10 plans a month. Cap: 30 plans per user per day.

YALLA TODAY Partly. Rate limits and caps on paid calls were added (merged). But cost per plan is unknown because no AI call is logged, and the limits reset whenever the server restarts.

You are done when: Monthly cost at expected volume is covered by value or price, with a cap that cannot be exceeded.

Before step 1: what the 8 steps assume you already did

The method starts at "mine the jobs". These are the things I would add in front. They are my additions as a product and engineering view, not part of the PDF's numbered steps.

Add	What it is, in plain words	Is it in the method?	Yalla
0a. One product number	Decide which number the feature should move, and what it is today. Without a starting number you can never say "AI made it better".	Not as a step. Its goal line is about the feature (passes the exam, users accept it, it pays for itself), not about your business number.	Candidates: share of sessions where a plan is picked, plans shared, groups that come back next weekend. Today none can be measured.
0b. Switch on logging first	Record every AI call (what went in, what came out, time, cost) and every user action (picked, swapped, removed, shared). Data you did not record can never be collected later.	Yes, but late. It sits in the "foundation" (model gateway) and in step 13.	The top gap. Nothing is logged. It blocks steps 4, 6, 7 and 8 from ever having real numbers.
0c. Data rights check	Are you allowed to use, store and show this data? Ask once, early.	One line in step 2 ("data exists and may be used").	Check the terms for Google Places data and caching, for content read from Instagram and TikTok, and what you tell users about their saved reels and profile.
0d. Foundations	Things built once and reused by every AI feature: one door to all models (gateway), a tool that runs the exam (eval harness), shared safety checks.	Yes, as a foundation layer, without a step number.	A good start exists: every AI call already goes through one wrapper. The exam runner is missing.
0e. An afternoon of AI basics	What a model is, where its knowledge comes from, what it costs, how it fails.	Yes: Part 1 of the PDF.	Read Part 1 once, then this guide is enough for daily work.

After step 8: what comes next

One thing I would add between 8 and 9: a go or no-go. The method gives you a one-page summary per feature (the "one-pager") filled during steps 1 to 8. I would make the decision explicit: sit with your engineer, read the page, and agree the smallest version to build, who owns it, and how many weeks. If the page has holes, you are not ready to build.

Then the method continues with 6 more steps, already in your PDF:

#	Step	In plain words	Yalla
9	Prompt and eval loop	Write the instructions for the AI, run the exam, fix, repeat until it passes.	Build the parser on a small model and run `parser.golden.json` on every change.
10	Add the safety net	Checks in normal code around the AI: block tricks, enforce the caps, an off switch.	Partly there: the AI can only pick from real place ids, and code re-checks opening hours.
11	Run the eval gate	One formal exam, including questions the team never saw. One decision: ship or not.	Not possible until the exam runs.
12	Roll out in stages	Silent test first, then the team, then a small group, then everyone.	Start with friends and a few real groups.
13	Measure in production	A dashboard someone really looks at every week: quality, acceptance, cost.	Needs the logging from 0b.
14	Improvement loop	Every month, real failures become new exam questions.	Swaps and removals are free "this was wrong" signals.

What I would still add after step 14 (I did not find these in the PDF):

- **Compare against the old version.** Show the new version to half the users and the old one to the other half (an A/B test), and check your product number from 0a. The method rolls out in stages but does not name this comparison.
- **A rule for removing a feature.** Decide in advance: if acceptance or cost stays below a line for some months, switch it off. The method has an emergency off switch, but no retirement rule.
- **Using the data beyond the exam.** Once you log what groups pick, that data can train a ranking and later real recommendations. Youssef's "data and recommendations" doc covers this path.

Where Yalla stands on the 8 steps

#	Step	Status	Why
1	Mine the jobs	**Done**	PRD lists jobs A to F.
2	Test the AI fit	**Partly**	Right on paper. In code the AI does maths, and code does the language job.
3	Autonomy level	**Partly**	Behaves as "draft" (L2). Not written down.
4	Golden set	**Partly**	Parser exam exists but nothing runs it. No exam for plans.
5	Pattern + knowledge	**Partly**	Target flow is designed in the AI review. Code still uses one big call.
6	Choose the model	**Missing**	Largest model everywhere, no exam numbers.
7	Trust UX	**Partly**	Swap, Add and warnings exist. No "why this?", no feedback captured.
8	Economics	**Partly**	Caps exist. Cost per plan unknown.

What I would do next, in order

1. **Turn on logging** (0b): AI calls and user actions. It unlocks every number in this guide.
2. **Merge the Swap and Add fix** and the AI docs. They sit on the branch `claude/ai-architecture-review-a430a4`, not yet in `main`.
3. **Build the parser on a small model** and run the existing exam on every change (steps 4, 6, 9). This also fixes Arabic input.
4. **Right-size the models** (step 6): small for reading reels and the status check.
5. **Move scheduling into code**, keep AI for understanding and for writing (steps 2 and 5), and compare against today's version.
6. **Measure cost per plan**, then decide the free limit and pricing (step 8).
7. **Write the autonomy paragraph** (step 3) before any booking feature.

> **The one sentence to remember:** use AI for language and taste, use code for rules and maths, write the exam before the prompt, and record everything from day one.

Sources: "The AI Feature Method: Building AI features into an existing product, A to Z" (steps 1 to 8 and the Yalla examples); the Yalla repository and Youssef Tekriti's AI review (November 2026). Cost figures in step 8 are the method's invented illustration, not Yalla's real costs.